

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 542

By Atchley

A RESOLUTION to recognize Pigeon Forge City Manager Earlene Teaster on the occasion of her retirement.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should specially recognize those citizens who have performed with uncommon devotion and enthusiasm throughout their years of public service; and

WHEREAS, Earlene Teaster is one such estimable individual, who has served for forty-four years as city manager of Pigeon Forge, from which position she is taking her much-deserved retirement on June 30, 2025; and

WHEREAS, a native of Sevier County, Ms. Teaster is distinguished by being the first woman to serve as a city manager in the State of Tennessee; having taken up the post of Pigeon Forge city manager in 1980, she is also the longest-serving city manager in the State's history; and

WHEREAS, her service to her hometown of Pigeon Forge spans sixty-three years in total, as she was first hired as city clerk in 1961, before advancing to serve as city recorder; and

WHEREAS, Earlene Teaster's impact on the City of Pigeon Forge is immeasurable; she recognized the gateway city's potential and has been a strong advocate for supporting tourism, the city's only industry, through partnership with local businesses and improved infrastructure; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Teaster guided efforts to establish new businesses, including Dollywood theme park, Tennessee's most visited ticketed attraction, in 1986, as well as the LeConte Center at Pigeon Forge in 2013 and the Ripken Experience Pigeon Forge in 2016; and

WHEREAS, she also led efforts to establish Pigeon Forge's Fun Time Trolley, which now functions as Pigeon Forge Mass Transit, the third-largest rural transit system in the United States; and

WHEREAS, under Ms. Teaster's leadership as city manager, Pigeon Forge has sustained record growth, achieving more than \$1 billion in annual revenue for eleven consecutive years; and

WHEREAS, she also guided her city through the 2016 wildfires and the COVID-19 pandemic; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Teaster was a member of the inaugural Leadership Sevier class and has served her community as a supporter of Pigeon Forge Schools and the Boys and Girls Club of Pigeon Forge; she is also a former Boy Scouts den mother; and

WHEREAS, she is a member of the Tennessee City Management Association and the International City/County Management Association; she has represented the tourism industry in various capacities on the East Tennessee Development Districts board; and

WHEREAS, often duly recognized for her good work, Ms. Teaster is a recipient of the J. Prichard Barnes Community Service Award and a member of both the Pigeon Forge High School and Sevier County High School halls of fame; and

WHEREAS, her professional accolades further include the Southeast Tourism Society's Shining Example Award and being named Tourism Leader of the Year in 1994 and Tennessee City Management Association's City Manager of the Year in 2000; and

WHEREAS, a woman of abiding faith, Earlene Teaster is an active member of Wears Valley First Baptist Church; and

WHEREAS, throughout her many years of service, she enjoyed the love and support of her husband, Glen, until his passing; she is the proud mother of two sons, Steve and Phil, the grandmother of five grandchildren, and the great-grandmother of four great-grandchildren; and

WHEREAS, Earlene Teaster exemplifies the spirit and allegiance to family and community that are characteristic of a true Tennessean; and

WHEREAS, throughout her illustrious tenure, Ms. Teaster has carried out her responsibilities with diligence and integrity, and her remarkable success as a public servant and civic leader cast the mold for all who will follow; and

WHEREAS, a strong advocate for the citizens of Pigeon Forge, Earlene Teaster has compiled a singular record of success during her exemplary public service career, and she should be specially recognized; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor and commend Earlene Teaster for her honorable and astute service to the people of Tennessee as city manager of Pigeon Forge and extend to her our best wishes for a happy and fulfilling retirement.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.